Chapter - 2

Modern Method of Learning Astrology

The original Indian tradition of learning Jyotisha by rote had great merit. The predictive principles were fed Into the computer of one's brain and some tricks were taught to recall the required principle within seconds, much faster than the fastest computer. I remember, many times when I met a well-known astrologer of Calcutta, Sri Smashaneshwar. telling me the exact chapter and verse of the voluminous Brihat-Parashara-Hora-Shastra, the great astrological classic from where he quoted when we discussed astrological niceties of a horoscope.

The facility and ease with which he did it, never surprised me. I had seen this great Sanskrit tradition of memorising stanzas after Stanzas by those who knew tight from their childhood that they had to prepare themselves for their traditional and family occupation. They kept alive that ancient knowledge through the oral tradition before the printing press made available many of those texts to astrologer for whom jyotisha is not a traditional occupation. Most of us have gone through modem English education first and later got Interested In Jyotisha as a serious pursuit. Or some persons memorised the stanzas In Sanskrit without any knowledge of Sanskrit as Dr. Raman had done then went through English education, and at some stage fell back upon those memorized stanzas for the profession, they decided to pursue finally.

The largest number of practising astrologers are those who neither have any classical learning not good English education. These *ate* the menaces and quacks In the astrological field that have endangered the super-scientific culture of jyotisha, which we describe as astrology very wrongly, not as the science of illumination, which It is.

The traditional method of learning by rote was the best way of learning jyotisha right from childhood as when the young astrologer grew up, he learnt the art of interpreting those stanzas In many new ways which could have been different from what was taught to him.

Smashaneshwar once quoted the combination of the Atmakaraka with the lord of a particular house to prove his point and win his debate with me. I could not have done that. How flexible he had become in his interpretation had always surprised me. The picture of a dogmatic *pandit sticking to* an old archaic astrological rule, not seeing it in the modern context of living, is a wrong picture of the classically well-trained astrologer who has had the opportunity of interacting with people always.

The classical method of learning had no substitute and can never have, But they were memory feats. I remember that in 1970 when I had met the late Swami Gangeshwarananda, the blind saint who died at the age of one hundred and ten years in 1993, how small I felt. I was, when he went on quoting from the Valmiki Ramayana, which has 1,20,000 stanzas, and from four Vedas, the Guru Granth Sahib and Tulsidas's Ramcharit Manas. Totalling all these, we calculated that he remembered nearly one million stanzas which he could quote more easily than I can drink water.

In our school days we were taught that T.B. Macaulay, the English parliamentarian remembered whole of *Paradise Lost of Milton* and that people were amazed at his phenomenal memory. If I had shown to my teachers and those Englishmen the ordinary Indian *pandit*, who remembered ten times more than what Macauly remembered what would have they said? The Indian method of learning and teaching can never have a substitute.

Here comes in the crux of the point. After years of learning when the disciple left the teacher's home, he left with many surras or aphorisms property memorised after understanding and assimilating them. *These were the memory tablets which helped him all his life.*

Through constant application of these sutras. be gained Insight into them and enriched the heritage. But the tragedy of the Indian tradition has been that this enriched knowledge which was kept a secret was not always passed on to succeeding generations. These aphorisms or stanzas became difficult to Interpret later. Now available in book-form, these aphorisms *are like our mysterious possessions which we proudly claim to have without understanding them well enough. This has been, and is, the greatest danger in the growth of a needed astrological discipline.*

The danger to Jyotisha comes more from certain new categories of practising astrologers. A majority of them have learnt more Sanskrit and less Jyotisha or have not tried to Interpret astrological rules in flexible ways. Their capadty to do damage is very great because they

can reel off quotations after quotations from their memory and stick to their dogmatic stand. Yet in the process, however acrimonious the debate may be, one learns so much.

It is better to argue with a dogmatic and well read pandit then with a lover of Jyotisha who has picked up a quotation or two or an observation or two like, "a retrograde benefic loses all its good qualities".

In the USA, "Vedic" astrologers are picking up this knowledge from books available in English. Most of them are translations of well-known classics done by persons who were either bad predictors or did not have enough illustrations to explain the meaning of the Sanskrit stanzas properly. If they follow the illustrations given in the books of Dr. Raman which has different *Ayanamsha*, they will get different vargas. They must follow the *Chitrapaksha ayanamsha* or Lahiri's.

A greater danger comes from the modern shallow educated person who picks up some rudiments of Jyotisha and proceeds to interpret his own chart and those of his family members. The growth in the numbers of such persons cannot be prevented because there are publishers ready to publish any work on Jyotisha, exploit the writer and make from ordinary to huge profits, never a loss. So the greater the growth of such writers, the greater will be the increase of this group which has a tremendous corrupting influence on Jyotisha and the individual psyche.

There exists, thus, a huge chasm between the classical, old and traditional group which is diminishing in number and the corrupting group of shallowly educated writers and reader of Jyotisha groups which cannot be controlled at all. Astrology is neither a licensed profession nor a recognised one, perhaps, anywhere in the world.

In the meantime, has come the influence of the USA on our educational system which has been is some ways good as we have had the benefits of using the sophisticated tools of modern technology. Their use has made us slaves and the modern Indian school boy will, over a period of time, forget the classical Indian method of learning some subjects by rote at the start of his educational career. *The art of feeding the computers in human brain early in life* has tremendous merit and great use later in life. That typical western habit of depending on the computer without and not within, has created a generation of 'compudiots' in the west where at a sales counter if the computer is out of order one will have to wait to pay the bill because the girl at the counter has forgotten simple additions or was not taught additions at all in her school days. An average Westerner over

dependent on the computer is forgetting the use of his brain. The story we were taught of man losing his tail during the course of his evolution because he had forgotten its use is perhaps repeating now. It is the brain now, not the tail.

Yet anyone who does Jyotisha seriously will discover that it is the science of sciences, complex in the beginning less complex later but never an easy subject where any mechanistic interpretation can be given. A horoscope needs a multi-pronged approach, methodical and scientific in analysis. This cannot be done without reviving the fine traditional methods of teaching it in modern times. But then no boy of five years in Indian families is earmarked for an astrological career in the changed India of our times. The danger of quacks and the corrupting group will always have its menacing presence undiminished.

The Technique I Evolved

In these circumstances, with such corrupting influences over present, when I started teaching Jyotisha as a hobby. I evolved the following:

a. Teach the basics of Jyotisha without asking the students in the age group between thirty and sixty generally to memorize anything. The alternative to memorizing was repeated exercises. I decided. It worked very well with about twenty or thirty percent cases in the beginning and later became so attractive that fifty percent students felt that it was most educative and also illuminating.

b. No teaching is done by me without actual horoscopic illustration. This has been become our standardized approach with the younger teachers as well because of which they could produced their astrological researches, the best in the world. The older teachers continued to teach only theoretically, produced no research and were almost turning our teaching institute into a kindergarten of Jyotisha. As always, this created jealousy, a rift and finally, a split.

c. In the higher classes, I started newer techniques, reviving old techniques like the Jaimini Jyotisha, with my own absolutely original and fundamental researches. The cream of the students learning these are the hopes of mine to become the fathers of the super-scientific Jyotisha of future decades.

d. Then my most innovative method of teaching has been to coin some memory tablets at the beginning, middle and the end of the lessons for students to remember the necessary steps they

have to follow in their astrological analysis of a horoscope. For instance the PAC/DARES tablets of mine have appealed to Americans so much that it has become an attractive teaching aid and standardized method of the analysis of a horoscope. I have also learnt that an American woman has plagiarised this memory tablet and has been claiming it to be her own invention!

PAM for calculating the span of life according to Jaimini method has helped me teach an entire chapter on the subject easily.

In giving actual predictions, the method I have evolved is a three memory tablet approach given in this book with illustrations

And then remember that you can develop your astrological skill only by working hard yourself. There is no parampara or tradition of astrology anywhere tn the country as there could not have been in the last two hundred years when we have been taught only through western methods and have neglected our traditional method of teaching. The introduction of English education in the third decade of the nineteenth century led to the disappearance or whittling down of the parampara of teaching. In the beginning of the twentieth century male literacy was less than ten percent and female literacy less than half percent. Generations of illiterates could not have kept alive their parampara. THEREFORE IF YOU COME ACROSS ANY HINDU ASTROLOGER CLAIMING TO BE BELONG TO A JYOTISH PARAMPARA REST ASSURED THAT HE MUST BE A CHEAT.

I have lived in all parts of India and interacted with astrologers who. I am sad to say, know only a smattering of astrology but have been practising it because they do not have educational qualifications to compete for better fobs. Some of them are quacks and most of them frauds who know less predictive astrology and make money through costly remedial measures as though they can wipe out anyone's karma through some undisclosed license granted to them by God.